

PROTECTION RISKS

Attacks on civilians and other unlawful killings, and attacks on civilian objects: In Jonglei, Upper Nile, and parts of Unity, between 226,000 and 280,000 civilians have been displaced, facing severe secondary protection risks. Vulnerable groups, including the elderly, women, children, and individuals with disabilities, are particularly affected, requiring mental health and psychosocial support (MHPSS) and facing dangers such as gender-based violence, family separations, and exposure to unexploded ordnance.

Child recruitment and association of children in armed forces and groups: Children and youth frequently become involved with armed groups during inter-communal conflicts in affected areas of the country. The causes include structural factors like income generation, community needs, and ineffective coping strategies, exacerbated by displacement. In the current conflict in Jonglei and Upper Nile, there is significant recruitment of children by armed forces, along with a decline in adherence to International Humanitarian Law by these groups. Between April and December 2025, 482 verified grave violations were documented against 322 children in South Sudan. Boys accounted for 70% of affected children, girls for 27%, and 3% were of unknown sex. The ratio of violations to children indicates that some children were subjected to multiple violations.

The most prevalent violations were recruitment and use (33%) and killing and maiming (33%), together accounting for two-thirds of all verified cases. Recruitment and use predominantly affected boys and reflect continued child association with armed actors. The high proportion of killing and maiming underscores children's sustained exposure to active hostilities and explosive violence.

Gender-based violence: A secondary risk associated with the displacement and assaults on civilians. As they move and reside in overcrowded displacement shelters while seeking livelihoods many women and girls face challenges due to deteriorating community structures. However, there is an exponentially growing concern regarding the rise in **reports of Conflict-related sexual violence (CRSV)**. With the current conflict settings, this has been brutality extreme. In 2025, rape and gang rape were the most frequently documented forms of CRSV compared to 2024, accounting for 81 per cent of all incidents. Specifically, rape accounted for 51 per cent of the total number of all incidents, while gang rape accounted for 30 per cent. Forced marriage followed with 7 per cent of incidents. Sexual slavery represented 6 per cent. Attempted forced marriage with 2 per cent. Other forms of CRSV, each, accounted for 1 per cent of the total incidents respectively.

Discrimination and stigmatization, denial of resources, opportunities, services and/or humanitarian access: Humanitarian actors operational in Jonglei and Upper Nile have on occasion witnessed access constraints as a tactic of besiegement and a driver of displacement, as well as an instrument for collective punishment. While some areas are accessible, guarantees are difficult to achieve and life-threatening incidents to humanitarian staff have been recorded.

February 2026 experienced renewed inter-communal violence in Upper Nile, resulting in 57 deaths and 65 injuries in Balliet and triggering retaliatory operation, which included aerial bombardments in Ulang later that month. Fighting between SSPDF and SPLA-iO in several locations of Jonglei State has intensified since December 2025, triggering repeated waves of displacement forcing up to 280,000 civilians to flee. There is renewed contamination exemplified by two accidents in Uror that injured three children and killed one.

FGD conducted among IDPs from Uror, Nyirol and Duk counties, Jonglei State in early February bring forward credible reports on child recruitment by parties to the conflict. Modalities include abduction and engagement under false pretence, for example guide services. Abductions of women and children during displacement were also highlighted by the community.

A report from early February IRNA, covering northern and central counties of Jonglei, highlights alarming occurrences of CRSV, such as rape, abduction, and sexual abuse among female IDPs. Women displaced by conflict have also shared instances of women and girls being killed for their resistance. Additionally, the reports reveal that women and girls face abduction, captivity, and sexual violence while trying to flee.

On 25th of January, the SSPDF military called for all NGO and UN personnel to leave from SPLA-iO controlled counties of Nyrol, Uror and Akobo.

POPULATION IN NEED

Conflict displacement severely impacts individuals who are forced to flee, creating a demand for critical support in food, shelter, sanitation, and protection. The UNHCR evaluation among internally displaced persons (IDPs) in Akobo reveals significant vulnerabilities, particularly among households led by women (72.6%), due to conflict-related male casualties. The typical household size is six, with many containing elderly individuals (59%) who serve as caregivers. Additionally, 14.5% of households include people with disabilities, struggling with accessibility and support needs, while at-risk children represent 8.2% of the population, often unaccompanied or facing exploitation. Women, particularly those at risk (30.8%), are most protection cases, with reports of gender-based violence (GBV) found in 4.1% of households. Health vulnerabilities affect 8.5% of households due to chronic medical issues. The demographic data underscores reliance on humanitarian aid and the necessity for protection-sensitive programs to address the needs of displaced women and elderly caregivers while mitigating social exclusion risks.



URGENT NEEDS AND MODALITIES

To address the needs of at-risk displaced individuals, the Protection Cluster recommends the temporary implementation of a **Minimum Service Package (MSP)** that includes low complexity case management, cash for protection, individual protection assistance, psycho-social support, and protection risk monitoring. It emphasizes enhancing these services with tailored actions like family tracing, reunification, and establishing safe spaces for Child Friendly Spaces (CFSs) and Women and Girls Friendly Spaces (WGFSSs). During the initial deployment, the cluster advises targeting at least 30% of the displaced population for MSP and monitoring referral mechanisms for potential scaling. It also highlights the necessity for robust clinical services for women, including 24/7 access to Post-Exposure Prophylaxis (PEP) and emergency contraception. Strengthening protection desks and implementing mobile outreach teams, along with improved protection assessments and increased trained case workers, are crucial. Resources such as Individual Protection Assistance (IPA) and cash for protection should support vulnerable households, especially those led by women, using assessment data to guide programming decisions.

MINIMUM SERVICE PACKAGE FOR LIFE-SAVING PROTECTION RESPONSE

People in imminent danger or who have recently faced a traumatic event require swift intervention by protection service providers to safeguard their safety and facilitate recovery. Case management is a critical ongoing effort that interrupts violence and guides clients in improving their circumstances. Conversely, cash for protection offers immediate, one-off aid to address acute safety risks, differing from multipurpose cash assistance (MPCA) that focuses on broader needs. Individual Protection Assistance (IPA) combines essential non-food items and protective information to meet urgent needs, especially crucial for displaced populations facing explosive hazards. Psychosocial support services (PSS) provide vital mental health interventions to help individuals cope with trauma. Protection actors must assess risks swiftly to facilitate access to necessary services, utilizing referral methods when specific services are unavailable. Mine action land release processes are vital for ensuring safe land utilization and enabling humanitarian aid delivery. Family tracing and reunification (FTR) are critical for restoring connections among separated family members, particularly for children at risk. Where safe spaces for protection services are lacking, temporary safe spaces for women and children are established to deliver psychosocial support, protection assistance, and vital information, while also facilitating referrals for specific needs. These safe spaces play a crucial role in delivering specialized protection services, even if they are not lifesaving in themselves.